

FIVE KEYS AFTER MIDNIGHT

STEP 1b RUN AS A PRE-MORTEM

2026-08-28. The standing champion after roughly 180 lines: **8.5, and the only line Stephen has called "definitely intriguing".**

Five friends receive keys after a woman's murder, each opening the cupboard where she hid proof that one of them planned her death.

★ **This is the first time the earliest-action sweep has been run BEFORE a spine instead of after one.** Both previous candidates cost a full day of spine work before the instrument found the hole. If it can kill a premise from one sentence, it should.

Verdict: SURVIVES, on three conditions. One of them is the condition that sank both previous candidates, and it must be solved before a word of spine is written.

What the sentence commits us to

Five things, none of them optional:

1. A woman was murdered.
 2. **She expected it**, enough to hide proof and make an arrangement.
 3. Five friends receive keys **after** she dies, so somebody executed her instruction.
 4. The cupboard holds proof that **one of the five planned it**.
 5. **The five are a closed set.** Each of them is a suspect to the other four.
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The sweep

Person	Earliest competent action	When	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Does the episode survive?
★ The first friend to reach the cupboard, if innocent	Open it, read it, take it to the police	★ Hour one	Police	★ A murder victim's own hidden proof, naming her killer. They act immediately	★★ NO. Episode over at lead one
★ The first friend to reach the cupboard, if guilty	Open it and destroy it	★ Hour one	Nobody	Nothing	★ Yes, and this is the only version that works. See condition B
Whoever holds the keys and posts them	Hand the whole arrangement to police, because it came from a murder victim	Day one	Police	★ They open the cupboard themselves before any friend does	★★ NO, unless condition A holds
The other four, once they know	Go to the police together	Within days	Police	"Our dead friend left us keys to an empty cupboard" is not evidence and cannot be acted on	✅ Yes. Correctly, nothing happens
The four, about each other	Talk to each other	Immediately	Each other	★ They cannot, because each of them is a suspect to the other three	✅ Yes, and this is the engine
Ally	Take it from whichever of the four calls her	Day one	Her audience	She has no power and never gains any	✅ Yes

★ THE THREE CONDITIONS

A. Her death was not treated as a murder at the time

Otherwise the arrangement goes straight to police and they open the cupboard first. A solicitor or executor holding an instruction from a murder victim hands it over, and any version where they do not is the *"unbelievable incompetence"* that killed six lines in round one.

So: her death was recorded as an accident, an overdose or a suicide. There was no investigation, so there was nobody for the keys to be given to. ★ That is also the show's own engine, the record being wrong, and it costs nothing.

△ **Consequence to accept now: the murder is not established at the top of the episode. Only the reader knows.** That is the third time this has come up and it needs handling in the opening, not later.

B. The cupboard is already empty

The premise as written cannot survive an innocent person opening it, because that person goes to the police in the first hour and the story ends.

★ **So the killer got there first, and the other four arrive to an empty cupboard.** What survives is not the evidence. It is **the certainty that one of the four people standing there took it**, which is a human problem rather than an evidential one, and it is far better drama.

Reject the alternative — a lock needing all five keys, or five keys to five parts of one proof. **That is a puzzle-box device**, and puzzle-box thinking is exactly what dropped round two's ceiling from 8.5 to 7.5.

C. △ SOMEBODY ALIVE MUST BE AT RISK, AND THE SENTENCE DOES NOT SUPPLY ONE

This is the condition that sank both previous candidates and it is unsolved here.

The stake in the line as written is justice, friendship and identity. All legitimate. **None of them is present danger, and "no body at the top plus no living jeopardy" is precisely the combination that moved The Same House Twice out of the pilot slot.**

It is cheap to fix and it must be fixed before the spine, not during it. The available answers, in the order I would take them:

1. ★ **One of the four is closest to the dead woman's family, and the killer knows which of them has started talking.**
2. The killer is now with somebody the dead woman loved.
3. The dead woman left a sixth key, and it has not been collected.

Do not write a spine until this is chosen. Both previous spines were written with this gap open and both were reworked because of it.

What the sweep did NOT catch

- **Nothing resolves too fast.** Once the cupboard is empty, the correct official response is that nothing can be done, and that is true rather than convenient.
- **No route is closed.** Every one of the four can go to the police, and does, and it changes nothing.
- **No paperwork.** The object is a key and an empty cupboard.
- **No small number carries a reversal.** Five is a cast size, not a measurement.
- **No child and no elderly person** is required by anything in the premise.
- ☒ **The closed set of five is the seam that has been working on this reader all week:** five keys, two sisters with identical statements, four men in a van, three friends telling one story.

VERDICT

Green, with condition C outstanding and blocking.

★ Two spines were written and reworked before this instrument found their hole. This time it took one page and no prose. If that is all the sweep ever does, it has paid for itself.

Next, in order: rule condition C · then the spine · then the pre-flight · then ChatGPT · then one opening from Fable.